move could justify his choice, instead, of countermoves that ran so high a risk of holocaust?

The mind searches for easy answers. Perhaps the President had no alternative. There is more than humor in Robert Kennedy's reply to his brother when, halfway down the confrontation track, John Kennedy wondered how they had ever started: "If you hadn't acted, you would have been impeached." No doubt, the President felt personally challenged. But none of these considerations suggest why he felt that such a choice was tolerable, rational, justifiable.

Answers to that question go to the heart of what we have termed the nuclear paradox: *in a world of mutual superiority, neither nation can win a nuclear war, but each must be willing to risk losing*. Consider each clause of the paradox. First, if war comes, both nations lose. There is no value for which rational leaders could reasonably choose the deaths of millions of their own citizens. In that sense, conditions make a President Kennedy and a Chairman Khrushchev partners in a game of preventing mutual disaster. But this is the condition of both nations and the leaders of both nations know it. Thus if one nation is unwilling to risk waging (losing) a nuclear war, the opponent can win any objective by threatening to take the dispute to that level of risk. In order to be able to preserve certain values, the leaders must be willing not to choose destruction, but nonetheless to choose the risk of destruction.

It could be argued that, despite the risk inherent in the course of action President Kennedy chose, any other course would have meant greater risk. If, rather than challenging Khrushchev and demanding withdrawal of the missiles, he simply had accepted Khrushchev's move and minimized its importance, what would the consequences have been? First, the "rules of the precarious status quo" that the President referred to during the crisis would have been seriously jeopardized. Outside the Ex Comm conference room in the State Department there was a sign: "In the nuclear age, superpowers make war like porcupines make love—carefully." Kennedy had tried to establish rules that would prevent either nation from miscalculating the other's vital interests and stumbling by misunderstanding into a confrontation from which neither could retreat. If Khrushchev's most serious infraction of these rules were disregarded, the rules would wear away. Second, the Soviet action constituted the most blatant breach of confidence and trust between Khrushchev and Kennedy. Kennedy had announced in the firmest terms possible that the United States would not tolerate Soviet offensive weapons in Cuba. Khrushchev had assured Kennedy that the Soviet Union would not place